

Instagram Explore Page Redesign

Improving Access to Direct Messages While Browsing Reels

Overview

Instagram allows users to discover new content through the Explore page. However, when a user taps on a Reel from Explore, the interface changes and the Explore navigation disappears. During this experience, users who receive a direct message or simply want to check their inbox have to leave the Reel, return to the Explore page, and then navigate to the Messages section. This interrupts the viewing experience and increases the chances of losing the Reel they were watching.

This redesign focuses on improving navigation by providing quicker access to Direct Messages without forcing users to leave their current viewing experience.

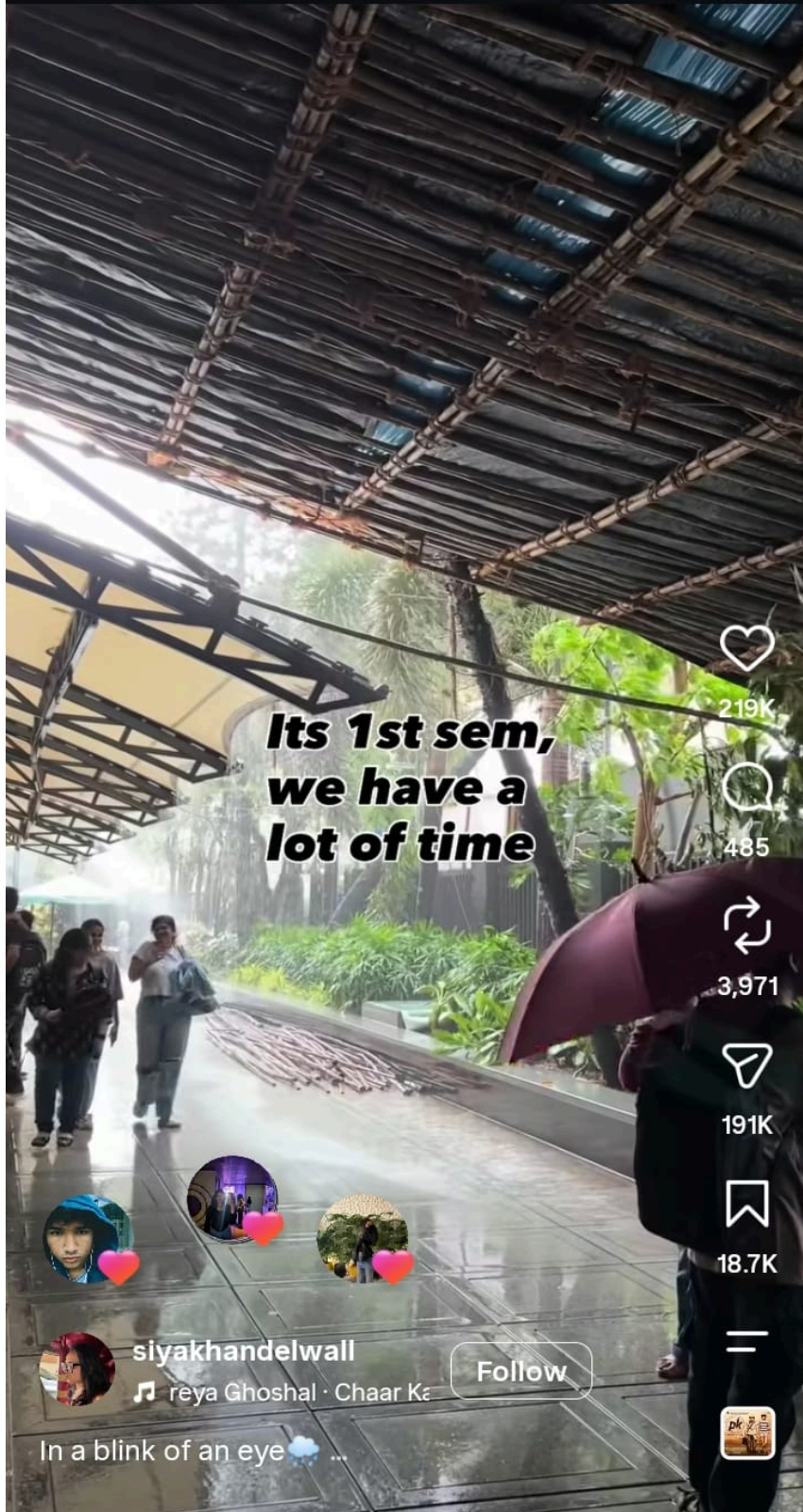
Problem Statement

While observing Instagram's Explore page, I noticed a small but frustrating usability issue. When users open a Reel from the Explore page, the bottom navigation remains visible, but there is no direct access to the Messages inbox. If a user receives a new message or wants to quickly reply to someone, they must exit the Reel, return to the previous Explore screen, and then access their inbox.

After replying to the message, returning to the same Reel is often difficult because the Explore feed may refresh, new content may appear, or the user may have forgotten the Reel's exact position. This creates unnecessary navigation and interrupts the user's browsing flow.

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User Problem

As a user, I want to quickly check or reply to my Direct Messages while watching a Reel from the Explore page without losing my current position, so I can continue enjoying the content without having to search for it again.

Research & Observation

During casual usage of Instagram, I observed that:

- Users frequently receive Direct Messages while browsing Reels.
- Opening Messages requires leaving the current viewing experience.
- Returning to the previously viewed Reel is not always easy because Explore content changes dynamically.
- This creates additional effort and breaks user engagement.

Although this is a small interaction, repeated interruptions can negatively affect the overall user experience.

Design Goal

The goal of this redesign is to reduce unnecessary navigation and help users maintain their viewing context while providing quicker access to Direct Messages.

The solution should:

- Provide immediate access to Messages.
 - Reduce the number of navigation steps.
 - Preserve the user's current viewing session.
 - Feel like a natural extension of Instagram's existing interface.
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Solution

To solve this problem, I introduced a **persistent Message icon** in the **top-right corner** while viewing Reels opened from the Explore page.

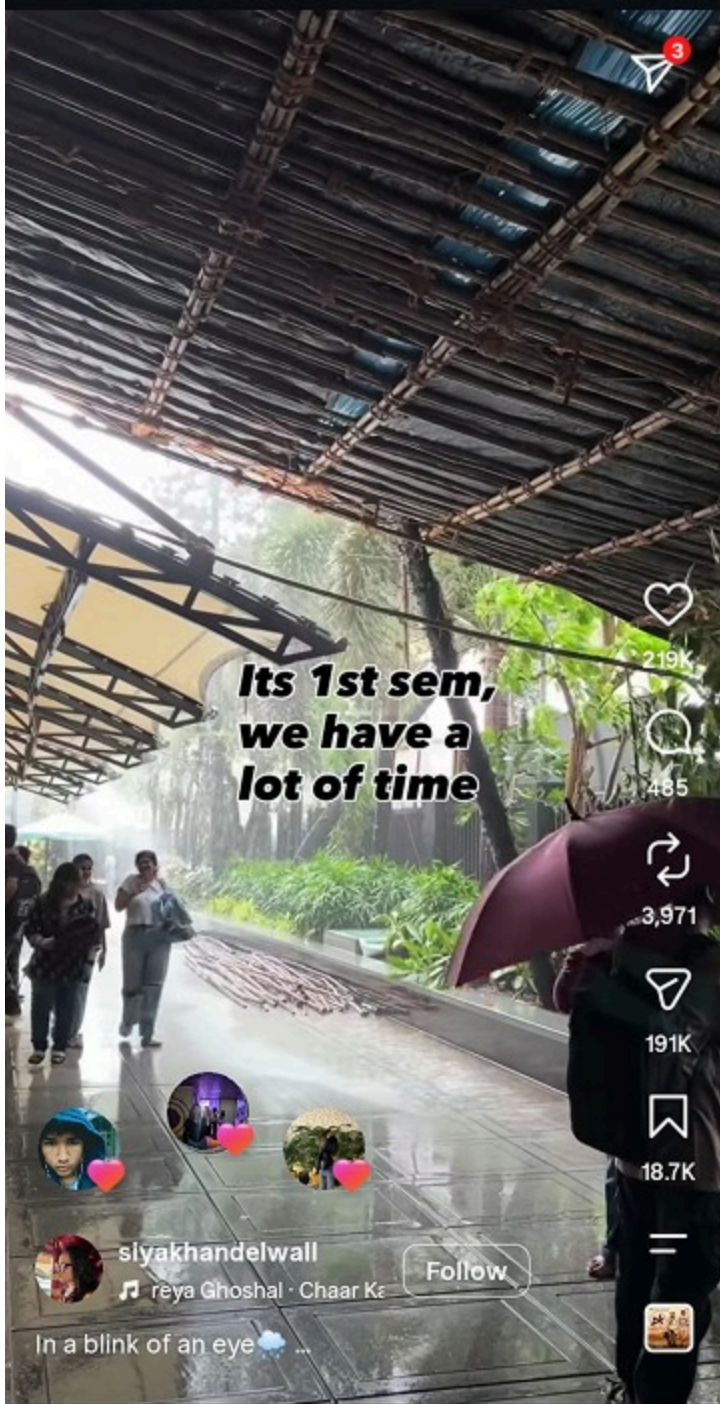
A small notification badge indicates unread messages, allowing users to immediately recognize when new conversations require attention.

Instead of leaving the Reel and navigating back through the Explore page, users can directly access their inbox from the current screen.

After checking or replying to messages, the application should return the user to the exact Reel they were previously watching, allowing them to continue their browsing experience without interruption.

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lot of time**



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3,971



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Why This Solution?

This solution was chosen because it requires only a small interface change while solving a common navigation problem.

The added Message icon:

- Improves accessibility.
 - Reduces unnecessary back navigation.
 - Keeps users engaged with content.
 - Makes multitasking between Reels and conversations easier.
 - Maintains Instagram's clean visual design without introducing major layout changes.
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Expected Impact

This redesign aims to improve the overall browsing experience by:

- Reducing friction when switching between Reels and Messages.
 - Helping users return to the same Reel after replying.
 - Improving efficiency through fewer interaction steps.
 - Increasing convenience without affecting the existing interface.
 - Supporting uninterrupted content consumption.
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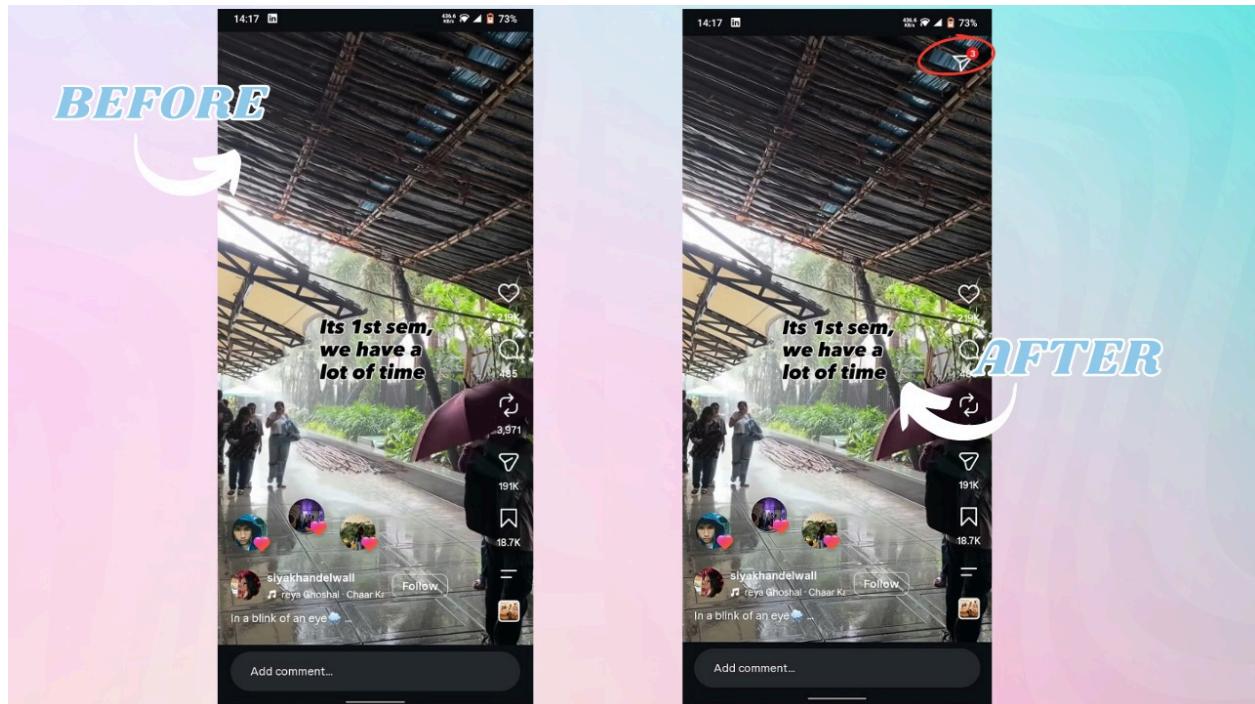
Assumptions

This concept assumes that after a user finishes viewing or replying to Direct Messages, Instagram restores them to the exact Reel they were watching before opening the inbox.

Since this is a conceptual redesign, the technical implementation of preserving the user's viewing state is outside the scope of this case study.

Reflection

This project demonstrates how a small interface improvement can solve a real usability problem. Rather than redesigning the entire Explore experience, I focused on addressing a single pain point through minimal but meaningful changes. The proposed solution aims to reduce interruptions, improve navigation efficiency, and create a smoother user experience while staying consistent with Instagram's existing design language.



Research & Observation

To confirm this wasn't just a personal frustration, I informally asked 3 regular Instagram users whether they'd experienced this issue. All three confirmed they've faced the same problem — receiving or wanting to check a DM while watching a Reel, and having to exit the Reel entirely to do so. Two of them mentioned they often lose track of the exact Reel afterward due to the Explore feed refreshing, and end up scrolling to find it again or giving up altogether.

This confirmed the issue wasn't isolated — it's a recurring friction point for users who actively use both Reels and DMs.

Alternatives Considered

Before finalizing the persistent icon approach, I considered two other directions:

- **Swipe-up message drawer** — letting users swipe up to preview messages without leaving the Reel. Rejected because swipe-up is already used to move to the next Reel, creating a gesture conflict.
- **Temporary notification banner** — a toast-style alert appearing only when a new DM arrives. Rejected because it only solves the case of *new* messages, not a user wanting to check their inbox in general.

The persistent icon was chosen because it handles both cases — new and existing messages — without clashing with Instagram's existing gestures, and it stays visually consistent with Instagram's icon-based navigation style.